

Expressive interfaces



- Provide reassuring feedback that can be both informative and fun
- But can also be intrusive, causing people to get annoyed and even angry
- Color, icons, sounds, graphical elements and animations are used to make the 'look and feel' of an interface appealing
 - conveys an emotional state
- In turn this can affect the usability of an interface
 - people are prepared to put up with certain aspects of an interface (e.g. slow download rate) if the end result is appealing and aesthetic



Friendly interfaces

- Microsoft pioneered friendly interfaces for technophobes - 'At home with Bob' software
- 3D metaphors based on familiar places (e.g. living rooms)
- Agents in the guise of pets (e.g. bunny, dog) were included to talk to the user
 - Make users feel more at ease and comfortable

Bob



Figure 5.6 'At home with Bob' software developed for Windows 95. Although now defunct, it has been resurrected affectionately to run on a Virtual PC platform

Source: Microsoft product screenshot reproduced with permission from Microsoft Corporation.

Clippy

- Why was Clippy disliked by so many?
- Was it annoying, distracting, patronising or other?
- What sort of user liked Clippy?

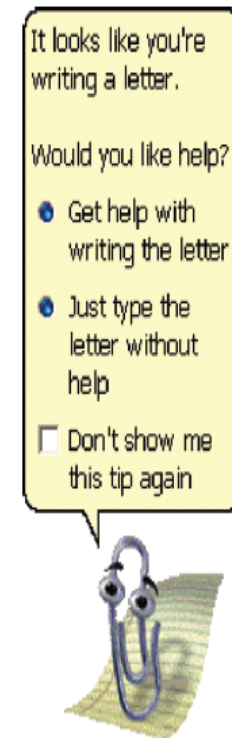


Figure 5.7 Microsoft's agent Clippy

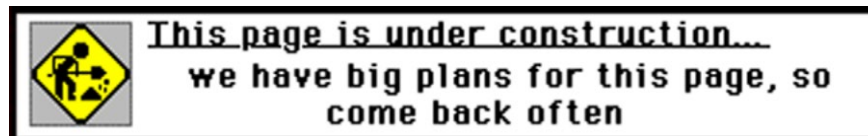
Source: Microsoft product screenshot reproduced with permission from Microsoft Corporation.

Frustrating interfaces

- Many causes:
 - When an application doesn't work properly or crashes
 - When a system doesn't do what the user wants it to do
 - When a user's expectations are not met
 - When a system does not provide sufficient information to enable the user to know what to do
 - When error messages pop up that are vague, obtuse or condemning
 - When the appearance of an interface is garish, noisy, gimmicky or patronizing
 - When a system requires users to carry out too many steps to perform a task, only to discover a mistake was made earlier and they need to start all over again

Gimmicks

- Amusing to the designer but not the user, e.g.
 - Clicking on a link to a website only to discover that it is still ‘under construction’



Error messages

“The application Word Wonder has unexpectedly quit due to a type 2 error.”

Why not instead:

“the application has *expectedly* quit due to poor coding in the operating system”

- Shneiderman’s guidelines for error messages include:
 - avoid using terms like FATAL, INVALID, BAD
 - Audio warnings
 - Avoid UPPERCASE and long code numbers
 - Messages should be precise rather than vague
 - Provide context-sensitive help

Website error messages

Error 404 – Web Page Not Found

Error!

Your login information is incorrect...

Please verify that you typed in your Last Name, NSF ID, and Password correctly. If you still cannot login, please contact the Administrator regarding your access rights.

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Figure 5.8 An error message that appears if a user types in his or her personal details for accessing the protected website incorrectly

More helpful error message

“The requested page **/helpme** is not available on the web server.

If you followed a link or bookmark to get to this page, please let us know, so that we can fix the problem. Please include the URL of the referring page as well as the URL of the missing page.

Otherwise check that you have typed the address of the web page correctly.

*The Web site you seek
Cannot be located, but
Countless more exist.”*

Should computers say they're sorry?

- Reeves and Naas (1996) argue that computers should be made to apologize
- Should emulate human etiquette
- Would users be as forgiving of computers saying sorry as people are of each other when saying sorry?
- How sincere would they think the computer was being? For example, after a system crash:
 - “I’ m really sorry I crashed. I’ ll try not to do it again”
- How else should computers communicate with users?